



matches...”

Among the four venues in India, only Navi Mumbai is a regular stop for women’s cricket, drawing packed crowds for India games and WPL fixtures. Organisers, however, chose Guwahati, Indore and Visakhapatnam to “spread the game” beyond traditional centres. Bengaluru was initially included but dropped after the Chinnaswamy Stadium stampede that killed at least 11 people during RCB’s IPL-winning celebrations. Notably, frequent hosts such as Delhi, Mohali, and Vadodara were left out. But Saikia stresses, “There are adequate practice facilities with all necessary requirements, there are enough top-tier hotels, so in terms of arrangements and logistics, we are absolutely well equipped.”

The ICC has priced tickets as low as Rs. 100 to attract young fans. Ahead of the opener between India and Sri Lanka in Guwahati on September 30, most stands are already sold out. But since this is the first major international event for several of the venues, the BCCI is taking “extra care” to ensure spectators have a smooth experience.

“We have deputed enough personnel to ensure that the hospitality area, the washrooms and the stands are clean, and provide all the facilities to the spectators. You have to understand that this is a long-term version of the game, where all the fans will have to be at the venue for seven to eight hours. So, it is our responsibility to ensure that they don’t face any challenges,”

Geared up: BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia says India is “perfectly ready” to host the Women’s ODI World Cup despite monsoon challenges. ^{AP}

Saikia says. “There will be proper food stalls, a dedicated housekeeping team to manage stands and washrooms, and all necessary facilities across the venues. The BCCI is giving top priority to crowd management and hospitality. We want the crowd to go back home happily once the match is over...”

Sponsorship has also surged. Industry experts estimate rates are up nearly 50 per cent, with title sponsorship valued at around Rs. 35 crore and co-sponsor packages in the Rs. 8-15 crore range. With major corporate groups on board, the ICC hopes to harness the momentum of women’s cricket and push the game to new heights.

“When Jay Shah was the secretary of the BCCI, he introduced the Women’s Premier League in 2023. After that, there has been a big movement throughout the nooks and corners of the country. Women’s cricket has got lots of popularity after the WPL was introduced, and we also introduced pay parity for women cricketers. So, when women’s cricket is taking such a high and big stage now, this World Cup will extend the movement which was initiated by the BCCI in 2022-23,” Saikia says.

“This event will give more encouragement to our women and our girls to take up cricket in a more serious, more competitive manner. And, they will see a proper and secured future in their career. So, this World Cup is not only about hosting matches, but it will also empower the Indian women to take their lives forward in a much more structured and disciplined way,” he adds.

Impressive recent performances against England and Australia have raised hopes for Harmanpreet Kaur’s side. As the World Cup approaches, the BCCI is confident the team can finally break the jinx at home.